

Musharraf? Short of a unified opposition boycott of the elections—an increasingly remote possibility right now—Musharraf can count the polls as a victory. With no party likely to win an absolute majority, a divided or hung Parliament will suit him and the establishment just fine. Both PPP and PML-N have historically never been able to poll more than 35-40 per cent of the votes. Post-election manipulations are easier when the competition for power-sharing is fierce, and whoever emerges as a winner will have to negotiate through the President to form a coalition government.

He has already indicated a return to the "troika" system of governance—practised during the 1990s "democratic decade"—involving the president, the prime minister and the army chief in an informal triumvirate of rulers. Sources indicate one of the first actions of his successor General Ashfaq Kayani will be to pull back the military from civilian governance, in particular yielding to popular pressure on the armed forces from civil society. Such a set-up, with the army continuing to back him as a civilian president, would be Musharraf's hope. Whether such an arrangement can work in the long-term—it never did for very long during 1990s when two presidents were also forced to resign—is questionable. Most analysts do not see such an arrangement lasting for more than two years.

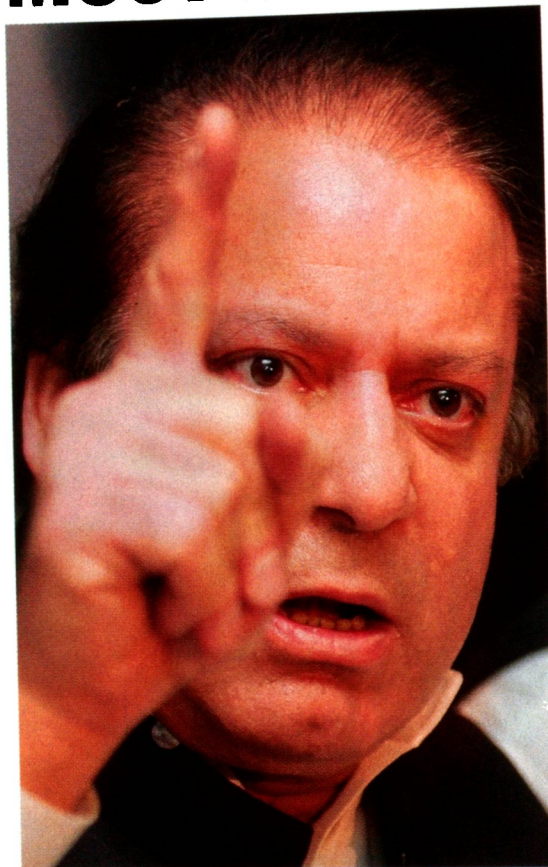
For the time being, Musharraf is still in power as President and he still has the backing of the army and the Americans. As for the army, habitually distrustful of politicians, it sees in Musharraf someone who will protect its interests at the top. Musharraf's own security, for example, will continue to be handled by a special unit of the army's Special Services Group.

However, even more dangerous than a security breach is Musharraf's own nature. "He is not very skillful at striking deals," says a former close aide, "and it's hard to see him resigning himself to a ceremonial role when he has been all powerful for eight years. There is bound to be conflict eventually."

The main threat to Musharraf may in fact come from himself.

INTERVIEW | NAWAZ SHARIF

"LIFTING EMERGENCY ISN'T ENOUGH. JUDGES MUST BE REINSTATED"



AP PHOTO GREG BAKER

After being ignominiously bundled back to Saudi Arabia when he first returned from exile to Pakistan in September, former prime minister Nawaz Sharif surprised everyone by returning home on November 25 to a rousing welcome. On the day that President Musharraf doffed his uniform, Nawaz Sharif spoke to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA over telephone from Lahore. Excerpts:

Q. As compared to the humiliation you had to face earlier, this time you seem to have made an honourable return to Pakistan. What has

changed in these intervening months?

A. When I came here on September 10 I was deported to Saudi Arabia despite a very clear verdict from the Supreme Court of Pakistan to allow me to enter. The Saudi authorities told me that I would be able to go back to my country very soon. It was the month of Ramzan and they said to wait till it got over. Before I left I went to meet King Abdullah and thank him for his kindness. He told me that he had conveyed to the Pakistani authorities about my role in Pakistan and the responsibilities and obligations that I had to fulfil. He said he told them it was not possible to hold on to Nawaz Sharif and that in the best interest of both the countries he must go

back. Mr Musharraf perhaps wanted that I shouldn't come back before elections. But the King thought otherwise.

Q. So there was no deal between Musharraf and you?

A. Not at all. I can't think of a deal with him. A deal is only possible if either I abandon my stand and start supporting dictatorship or Mr Musharraf abandons his stand and starts supporting democracy.

He would perhaps have to make a big compromise.

There was a proposal to have a meeting but I don't think it would have served any purpose. By the grace

"I have no deal with Musharraf. All I want is a level playing field."